

Tomato, Greenhouse.



HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Tomato plants are found in the majority of greenhouses during summer, producing a succession of fruit from early summer into autumn. They need constant care: water growing bags or pots regularly in summer and watch for pests and diseases. Home growers can choose flavours and varieties that are rarely sold commercially. Tall or cordon plants are trained with one central stem and their side-shoots removed throughout the season. They need warmth, light, steady root moisture, good ventilation and balanced fertility more than sheer feeding.

Quick facts



Sow

Feb – Mar



Harvest

Jul – Oct



Germination

8–11 days



Yield per plant

8 lb



Ready in

About 16 weeks from sowing

Growing calendar



Bright: usual months · Muted: less usual

Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high



Sun

4/5



Water

4/5



Nutrition

4/5

Recommended varieties

ORDINARY

Alicante

A reliable red salad cordon with fleshy, medium-sized fruit and good flavour.

BEEFSTEAK

Dombito

A distinct beefsteak hybrid with thick, fleshy fruit, around ¾ lb in favourable conditions.

F1 HYBRID

Estrella

A greenhouse hybrid retained as a distinct selection.

ORDINARY

Ailsa Craig

Another popular variety, producing brightly coloured, medium-sized tomatoes.

F1 HYBRID

Cherry Belle

A productive cherry hybrid with small red fruits and good flavour.

ORDINARY

Moneycross

A red salad tomato related to Moneymaker.

Key risks



BLIGHT

Tomato blight causes brown lesions on leaves and stems, followed by fruit decay and plant collapse in favourable damp conditions.



Greenhouse Whitefly

Whitefly adults and immature stages suck sap; sticky honeydew can support black sooty mould.



Blossom End Rot

A dark, leathery patch at the flower end of the fruit results from insufficient calcium reaching developing tissue, often because root moisture fluctuates.



SPLIT FRUIT

Irregular watering, particularly soaking after severe drying, can split ripe fruit.



Growing & harvesting

Water steadily and ventilate.

Even root moisture and moving air help fruit develop without splits or mould.

Train to the variety's habit.

Remove side shoots from cordons; bush types need a different routine.

Soil & preparation

1. Use fertile, well-drained border soil enriched with compost, or suitable pots and growing bags with fresh peat-free compost.
2. Avoid waterlogging and stale humid air. Containers need closer watering and feeding attention than a well-prepared border.

Looking after the crop

1. Tie cordons loosely, remove young side shoots and take off yellow lower leaves sparingly. Stop two leaves above the final truss at the chosen height or near season's end. Retain healthy foliage to feed and shade fruit. Follow separate pruning instructions for bush and semi-determinate varieties.
2. Water roots steadily and feed organically at the product's rate as fruit develops. Ventilate in heat, tap flowering trusses gently and adjust autumn watering to growth. Dry-to-wet swings encourage splitting and blossom-end rot.

Harvesting & storage

- Pick fully coloured fruit gently and use promptly. Bring sound unripe fruit indoors before cold ends the crop; check ripening trays and discard decay. Ripen at room temperature; a ripe apple or banana nearby can help.

Sowing & planting

1 Grow on in a pot



Sow in trays or small pots, keeping compost moist but not wet. Prick out and pot on as needed; keep seedlings bright for stout stems.

2 Plant and support



Plant well-rooted plants into pots, growbags or a soil bed once the greenhouse is warm. Water first, set slightly deeper and support cordons with a cane or string.

Pots / growbags One plant per 12–18 in. diameter pot; two per standard growbag. Use peat-free potting compost.

Pot spacing For upright cordons, allow about 24 in. between pot centres so foliage has room.

Soil beds 18–24 in. between plants in compost-enriched soil; use the wider spacing for vigorous cordons and airflow.

For unheated cover, sow around March in gentle warmth near 68°F. Earlier heated-house crops need reliable warmth and bright light through winter.

Pests & diseases

Problem	What to look for	What to do
BLIGHT	Brown leaf lesions; fruit may rot.	Remove infected plants; keep leaves dry and ventilate.
Greenhouse Whitefly	White flies, sticky leaves and sooty mould.	Identify early; use suitable biological control.
Blossom End Rot	Dark leathery patch at fruit base.	Keep root moisture even, especially as fruit swells.
SPLIT FRUIT	Skins crack after uneven watering.	Keep moisture steady; avoid drying then flooding.
Tomato Leaf Mould	Yellow patches above; brown mould below.	Remove infected leaves; ventilate and avoid wet foliage.
Aphids	Colonies gather on young growth.	Tolerate light colonies; squash damaging ones and favour predators.
Grey Mould (Botrytis)	Grey mould on damaged stems or fruit.	Remove infected tissue; ventilate and clear dead material.
Blossom Drop	Flowers wither and fall without setting.	Water steadily, ventilate in heat and gently tap trusses.
Virus	Mottled, distorted leaves; stunted plants.	Remove affected plants; clean hands/tools and monitor aphids.
Magnesium Deficiency	Lower leaves yellow between green veins.	Check watering, pH and feed; avoid excess potash.

Final tips



Check leaf undersides often so whitefly can be managed while numbers are still low.



Avoid high-potash overfeeding; balanced nutrition matters as much as the amount supplied.